
Task review – Mark Ruffalo's druggy kidnap drama is so bleak it's downright manipulative

Published by

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Estimated reading time

3 min

Added on

2025-09-09

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/tv-and-radio/2025/sep/08/task-review-mark-ruffalo-druggy-kidnap-drama-is-so-bleak-its-downright-manipulative>

Task review – Mark Ruffalo's druggy kidnap drama is so bleak it's downright manipulative

Do you feel it? There is a ripple in the firmament, a vibration in the foundations, a bracing of the cosmos ... yes, [Mark Ruffalo](#) is preparing to Act again. This time, he stars in crime drama Task, created by Mare of Easttown's Brad Inglesby, as a former priest turned FBI agent nursing a great sorrow in the suitably grey environs of suburban Philadelphia. Tom Brandis ends every day in a drunken semi-stupor and begins every morning with prayer and a head-dunk into an ice-filled sink. Do you think we might be in for a meditation on guilt, sin and the possibility of redemption? Yes, I wearily agree.

So. Brandis is taken off the desk duties he has been assigned since his great sorrow. This is evidently connected to the sentencing hearing for a third-degree murder conviction he is due to attend next week, where his daughter Emily may be giving a family impact statement – but we will have to wait just long enough for it to feel outright manipulative before we get the full explanation of who killed who and how. Brandis is assigned to a new taskforce to investigate a series of armed break-ins at drug houses owned by the Dark Hearts biker gang, in the hope that arrests can be made before Philly is consumed by a turf war. He has three youngsters to help him: the charmingly arrogant, Catholic-raised Anthony (Fabien Frankel); the supremely competent Aleah (Thuso Mbedu); and the supremely incompetent Lizzie (Alison Oliver). Their single characteristics allow Brandis to prove his priestly credentials (God-talks with the lapsed Anthony), his generosity of spirit (this middle-aged man is not threatened by youthful ability!) and patience (I would return her to Quantico instantly, bearing a large label that read "Not fit for purpose") and not much else.

The raids are being conducted by garbagemen and best friends Robbie (Tom Pelphrey) and Cliff (Raúl Castillo), who can tell from the trash cans on their route which dealers' houses have recently disposed of drugs and filled up with cash. How they know which are Dark Hearts facilities and why they are specialising in those will again become clear in the fullness of time. They are accompanied on the raids by younger friend Peaches (Owen Teague), who you might suspect is marked for death the moment he expresses his joy at the fact that he has just become engaged. I couldn't possibly comment.

Apropos nothing, Task ticks all the expected boxes. There are bloody shootouts, corpses and bags full of fentanyl instead of cash grabbed in chaotic getaways which will then require selling. Which requires finding a buyer. Which requires becoming further enmeshed in the drugs world – and more identifiable to those seeking to destroy you for killing their men and taking their 12 kilos of fentanyl in the first place. Especially as you also kidnapped a child witness in the process.

Now, Mare of Easttown was no picnic. But it had plenty of black humour and was full of vividly drawn, wholly believable family relationships and friendships that gave it a sense of life in the round. The criminality mattered because it affected people in all walks of life. Task, by contrast, is relentlessly bleak, humourless and narratively airless. It is not just the Brandis family that is crushed by terrible griefs and burdens. Robbie's wife has left him and he is mourning the death of his brother Billy. His niece Maeve (Emilia Jones), Billy's daughter, is dying by inches under the strain of looking after Robbie's motherless children, which does not seem a fair trade for letting him move in with her after her father's death left her with a house.

It flattens the characters into ciphers, deadens the story and as time goes on, makes the whole thing inescapably boring. It is not as if we haven't seen everything on show before. Let's find another way to propel a plot – or maybe even find another plot entirely – especially in Philadelphia.

But if formulaic yet weighty stuff is your bag, if gestures towards bigger issues rather than actual interrogations of them are all you're up to at the moment, then a relatively enjoyable Task lies before you. For anything else, you can always rewatch Mare of Easttown.

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